

Nimble

A fast, tactical TTRPG



Creator's Kit

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CREATOR'S KIT

Welcome to creating for *Nimble*! The guidelines in this document are here to help you craft content that plays fast, fun, and in tune with the spirit of the game. Think of them as a launchpad—not a rulebook carved in stone. Once you've got a handle on what makes *Nimble* tick, feel free to bend, twist, or toss these suggestions aside to suit your vision.

Understanding the framework is just the first step—breaking these guidelines for a good reason is where the magic happens. So dive in, experiment, and start creating!

— Evan @ Nimble co.

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AVOID FIDDLINESS

Fiddliness: *clunky, overly complex, or tedious mechanical overhead that slows down play and distracts from the core fun.*

Can I do this in fewer steps?

A single in-game action should typically take only one single real-world action to resolve. Fight the urge to add steps (saves, extra dice, etc.) wherever possible! Ask if the effect can simply *happen* automatically, or when something *else* does.

How long an action takes to resolve isn't about being in a hurry, it's about concentrating on the fun. Fiddly mechanics dilute the fun, spreading the same amount of fun out over a longer period of time. Take, for example, monster armor. Initially in development it reduced damage by a flat amount. Mathematically this worked, but mechanically it added an additional step to resolve. It didn't take very long, but multiplied over the dozens of attacks in an encounter, or thousands of attacks in a campaign, it was a suboptimal solution as it took up a significant amount of time.

Asking the question, "Can I do this in fewer steps?" is how Nimble landed on how monster armor currently works. Same end result, but with fewer mechanics getting in the way. This means more time for additional combat, story, roleplaying, and goofing off!

Find a way to eliminate as many steps as possible. Think this way with all of your design: Recognize how many steps are needed to resolve an action and eliminate as many as possible. Think of how it will be physically resolved at the table.

Can I make the calculation easier?

Math is inextricably tied to TTRPGS, it's part of the fun! But we should avoid anything but the simplest, quickest, calculations that can be done in one's head. Even very simple calculations, when there are a lot of them can grind play down to a halt and kill momentum. So we should avoid rolling and summing too many dice at a time. Summing at most 3–4 smaller dice or 2–3 larger dice is a good rule of thumb. More

than that, and players will often have to hunt for extra dice, roll them (increasing the odds that one lands cocked, rolls off the table, etc. eating up more time), and adding them all up takes longer as well.

Rolling LOTS of dice is fun—*sometimes*. It can quickly turn into a chore and add slog to the game when required too often. Lots of dice eliminates variability as well, the more dice that are rolled the more likely you'll end up with an average result. A fistful of dice should be special and rare.

Where possible think of creative solutions to more quickly generate high numbers. In the core rules we use LVL, d20s, d100s, dXX, or flat damage (e.g. Condemn deals a flat 30 damage, this could have been 12d4, or 9d6. That would have dealt the same amount of damage, but would have taken much, much longer to accomplish).

Exceptions. *Iconic or very large spells (e.g., tier 8 or 9 spells) or abilities that happen rarely (1/safe rest) can bend or break this rule of thumb, but cantrips or abilities that could happen multiple times in an encounter or even multiple times each turn should be **especially** quick to resolve.*



- Build mechanics where players can *immediately see* the result rather than *find* the result (adding dice). Rolling 1d12 with advantage is easier than rolling and adding 2d8. Both have a similar average result but, one requires no math, the other does.
- Avoid dividing by anything other than 1/2 (and even that shouldn't happen too often).
- Avoid multiplying difficult numbers ($\times 2$ is easy, $\times 13$ is not).
- Avoid adding multi-digit numbers (2+2 is easy, 7+16 is a bit harder). Again, it isn't that players *can't* perform these operations, it's that they *take longer than necessary* and add small bits of friction to the game. Those bits add up to

create SLOG.

- Design around easy increments of 2, 5, and 10 as flat modifiers where possible.
- Avoid adding multiple large dice. For instance rolling 4d6 and summing a result of 3, 4, 1, 5 is easy. Rolling 4d12 and a result of 7, 5, 9, 11 is a bit harder. Rolling 4d20 and a result of 7, 16, 19, & 14 is more challenging still.

Much easier would be something like 2d6+5, 1d12+20, 1d20+30. They have a similar average result but resolve much more quickly.

For instance, look at how the Cheat's Sneak Attack began (as much as 10d6 at high levels), to where it ended up (1d20+20). Much better!

MAINTAIN THE FLOW!

Play proceeds most quickly when each player can take their turn without interruption and without waiting on anyone else. This is *Flow*. Actions that interrupt the Flow should ideally be both **important** and **rare**. Failing that, they should at least happen **asynchronously**.

Important & Rare. A great example of this is Interposing for a Dying ally. This is both very important, and likely happen only on occasion.

Asynchronous. Reactions like Defend do technically interrupt the Flow, and they can happen rather commonly (each turn) are relatively low impact. The saving grace is that this happens asynchronously, or off turn. A hero choosing to Defend can privately calculate their HP without slowing anyone else down. The GM doesn't care (or even need to know) when a Hero Defends. That's between them and their character sheet.

Any fiddliness, especially if it disrupts the Flow, should happen off-turn whenever possible. See the Oathsworn's Judgment Dice, and the Berkerker's "That all you got?!" Those dice are rolled or expended when it's not their turn. No one else needs to wait for those actions to resolve.

THE WORST OFFENDER

The worst offender for breaking the Flow is **any mechanic that requires information from another player before proceeding** (e.g., in older d20 fantasy games: rolling to hit vs AC, rolling initiative, or saving throws). These are common (they happen for EVERY attack), are often low impact (it would not be game breaking if it just *happened*), and completely halt play for everyone until the multiple steps and back-and-forth is resolved. Avoid these mechanics like the plague if you want the game to run smoothly.

This is why saves should be quite rare and meaningful. If a save **MUST** take place, consider if you can have it not tied to damage but an additional extra effect. This way if 3 of the 4 targets die first, you only need to roll 1 save instead of 4. Saves should be... *saved* for very meaningful (e.g., ones that can apply powerful conditions) or uncommonly used abilities (e.g., 1/encounter). Cantrips and low level spells should NOT require a save or any other feedback from other players.

Take a look at how these spells changed over the course of playtesting:

OLD VERSION

Entice Cantrip, 1 Action, Single Target
WIL Save. The target takes 1d6 damage and moves 2

spaces closer to you. Repeat until they save.

Note that this initial version potentially required numerous save rolls AND damage rolls; combine that with this being a low impact cantrip, it could conceivably be cast 3 or more times EVERY ROUND. It took far too long to resolve this single spell. So it was simplified to resolve very quickly and a small bonus was added to compensate.

FINAL VERSION

Entice *Cantrip, 1 Action, Single Target*

DAMAGE: 1d4 (ignoring armor). On hit: target moves 2 spaces closer to you.

The final version uses a single roll to both determine damage and movement. Instead of a save, a d4 was used as the damage die to put a reasonable limit on how often this can apply the Taunted condition each round. Similarly, let's take a look at the initial version of Vicious Mockery:

OLD VERSION

Vicious Mockery *Cantrip, 1 Action*

Will Save. 1d6 psychic damage. The target's next attack is made with disadvantage. +1d6 damage every 5th level.

Note that this initial version breaks many of the guidelines. It is a low impact cantrip that requires a save. Lacks clarity (if I land this twice, are their next 2 attacks with Disadvantage, or their next single attack made with Disadvantage 2?), and the spell adds dice as one levels up (up to a maximum of 5d6 at level 20). Too fiddly, too slow. Here's the updated final version:

FINAL VERSION

Vicious Mockery *Cantrip, 1 Action*

DAMAGE: 1d4+INT psychic (ignoring armor). On hit: the target is Taunted during their next turn. +2 damage every 5 levels.

The final version of the spell does essentially the same thing (a small amount of damage and a debuff), but does it in a more streamlined, clear,

fun, and intuitive way.

Special attention must go toward ensuring that each action is simple and quick to resolve. Each step doesn't take long, but multiplied across every attack, every round, it adds up to slog. People start checking their phones, losing interest, and can't do as much cool stuff.

Flow should be maximized and interruptions minimized. If there is an interruption it should be minimal (in terms of how long it takes to resolve) big (in terms of the result it has on the gamestate), heroic (or conniving—for the bad guys), and rare.

The fun comes from how all of these simple pieces interact with each other and how the heroes and monsters shape the story. Complex rules elements that take a long time to physically perform don't add to the fun, they detract from it.



CONDITIONS

Tracking Game States. Be very careful with conditions and other game states that need to be tracked. Mechanics like this are really great for a videogame where the computer can handle the fiddliness, but for a manually resolved TTRPG it can become a big headache. These frequently result in interrupting the Flow as players remind others about the ongoing state, adding friction and slowing play down.

With this in mind, damage over time should be avoided completely. All damage should be resolved as the attack resolves. Conditions that have a visual component like Prone are easier to remember since

you can physically knock the miniature over to represent it. Other conditions that cannot be represented visually should be minimized.

Monsters (or heroes) that can apply 1 condition, or temporary conditions that last only a single round, are fine. When there are multiple different conditions to track simultaneously the fun doesn't increase with the number of game states, generally it decreases.

If something **MUST** be tracked, make it as easy as possible. For instance see the Hexbinder class, all of their afflictions apply only to a *single* monster, and other players need not remember any of them.

CLASS FRAMEWORK

It's not very fun to have to wait until level 14+ to see a hero's build fully come online. Try hard to "front load" the really cool things by levels 5-7 (without making the very early levels overly complicated or busy). A class should feel quite complete by then, with additional levels simply giving more options and power, but the class fantasy should already be fully unlocked.

Level 1. Should give a small taste of the unique mechanics of the class. Think simple and flavorful. Level 1 should NOT include any additional choices. There are enough choices being made at level 1 already: class, ancestry, stats, background, etc. no need to slow things down further.

Level 2. You can introduce 1 or 2 pieces of additional mechanical complexity (e.g., mana, more options to

use their resource), just not too much.

Level 3. Subclass choice. Each subclass should push the class in one particular direction: more offensive, more defensive, better at range, better at buffing allies, better at hindering enemies, etc.

Utility! Around levels 2-4 a class will typically get some fun out of combat utility ability as well.

Level 4. By now you are nearly a fully fledged hero. Typically introduces a big choice from among a list of class options. (e.g. Savage Arsenal or Underhanded Abilities). Classes with a lot going on already may have their options at later levels. Simpler classes may have class options more frequently. Aim to have enough options so that by level 20 a hero would have chosen roughly 1/2 to 2/3 of them.

Level 5 & 10. Typically a big damage increase or other large jump in power level.

Levels 7, 11, & 15. Additional subclass boons. Do something you can already do, but better/more often. Gain a new iconic ability. Fill in a weakness. Overcome a common constraint other classes have.

Levels 4, 8, 12, & 16. Key Stat Increase. and a optionally another small boost (e.g., unlock an additional tier of spells).

Levels 5, 9, 13, & 17. Secondary Stat increase and a larger boost.

Levels 18, 19, & 20. Big feature (LVL 18), Epic



Boon (LVL 19), Capstone (LVL 20). Very few people will ever play beyond levels 10-12, even fewer will reach level these levels—but don't let this stop you from really putting in the work to make sure the higher levels remain interesting! Level 20 in particular should be a BIG DREAM type of ability. Something players can think about, theorycraft with, and imagine being awesome using it. It should serve as a motivation to play the class, even if they never reach level 20, it's fun to dream of "how awesome it would be if..."

RESTING

There are NO per day or per field rest abilities. Field rests should be identical for every class, they are only to regain lost gain HP. Otherwise the party can be divided, some wanting to continue adventuring, others wanting to rest after every encounter. See the 5e Warlock and Monk as somewhat infamous examples of this dynamic.

Players will often adopt "optimal" but unfun play patterns if allowed. Don't create mechanics that incentivize playing unheroically or annoyingly. GMs can disallow frequent rests at their own table by forcing "random encounters" upon the party, but that just further slows the story down and is a band-aid. Or they can homebrew a rule, but then risk becoming "the bad guy" not letting their players play how they want. Best to have the rules as written be the bad guy.

Don't incentivize sitting around and doing nothing. The optimal thing should also be the most fun, most heroic thing.

HOARDING & GOING NOVA

Intelligently saving and using resources can be very fun, but their extremes: hoarding (NEVER spending resources) and going nova (immediately spending ALL of your resources) are both generally unfun play patterns. Since it can trivialize challenging encounters, or characters can feel underpowered or bored if they have spent all of their resources and have no way to regain it (or are afraid to spend them). Also frequently players will guess incorrectly when to hoard (going back to town with plenty of mana

remaining) and when to spend their resources (there is another big monster right around the corner).

Lean toward "per encounter" and similar abilities, and you can encourage the wise spending of resources by allowing heroes to regain a small amount of spent resources temporarily.

LANE PROTECTION

Be careful not to step on the toes of other classes, maintain the unique mechanics and flavor of each class. No two classes should deal damage the same way, avoid damage the same way, move around the same way, etc. They should all fill a unique role and feel different to play. No class other than the Mage should have access to 3 spell schools and deal damage primarily through spending mana casting spells. No other class should get their damage increased when they are attacked, and no other class should be able to freely Interpose—that is the domain of the Oathsworn.

RETRAINING

In Nimble, heroes can retrain chosen abilities during a Safe Rest, think of a fun/thematic task the hero can perform to engage with the world and role play the means by which they choose new skills. Think of ways to get heroes to look for new NPCs, new areas and ask questions of the GM to retrain. This allows the GM to introduce important new allies, environs, or even new problems and quests (the local wizard/soldier who retrains the mage/commander can ask for a favor afterward).

MULTICLASSING

Don't worry about building or balancing classes & subclasses with multi-classing in mind. That will exponentially complicate your work and also dilute the fun of the base class. It's okay for multiclassing to be overpowered, easy to break, and a bit silly. Let it happen, and leave it to local GMs to adjudicate or even to allow it or not.

USE PLAIN LANGUAGE

Avoid overly wordy explanations designed to block "rules lawyers"—those who might exploit technicalities—since this can make the rules harder to read and less enjoyable for most players. Instead, write in a way that's clear and concise, over exhaustive detail that tries to cover every possible loophole. Trust the heroes and GM to interpret the rules sensibly, and don't let the fear of rules lawyers bog down your writing with complexity. If you can also prevent rules exploitation without making the text longer or harder to read, that's fine—but never sacrifice readability for it.

Take for example, the Birdfolk ancestry boon was initially worded: *"You have a fly speed as long as you are wearing Leather or lighter armor."* Compared to how it ended up in the final version: *"You have a fly Speed as long as you are wearing armor no heavier than Leather."* Both are brief and easy to read, but the second also prevents the GM from having to deal with unfun technicalities ("but I'm wearing Plate AND Leather armor so...").

For an example of a change that was overly wordy and technical, look at the rules for dual wielding. The rules do not go into deep detail about attackign with different sized weapons and multiple instances of disadvantage and other edge cases. A simple example is given, and the GM can adjudicate any edge cases with the rules given.

Additional Clarity. If such is needed, can be supplied in sidebars or FAQ!

We should aim for brevity, even when clarity isn't

an issue. For example, here is a comparison of how one feature was initially worded VS how it ended up in the final books:

OLD VERSION

Key Attribute Increase. *You may increase one of your key attributes (STR or DEX) by +1.*

FINAL VERSION

Key Stat Increase. *+1 STR or DEX.*

"Stat" is more clear (and shorter) than "Attribute," and we can cut an entire sentence, communicating the same idea in much fewer words. It may take a few rounds of revisions to hone your wording, but it's worth it!

A note on brevity. Be careful not to be so brief that a newcomer couldn't understand it!

NAMING CLASSES

Use class names that do not have lots of built-in preconceptions. This will free you from explaining why your warlock or your sorcerer works this way instead of "how it's supposed to work".

STATS, SKILLS, & EQUIPMENT PROFICIENCIES

Be VERY careful handing out shield and wand proficiency. They are VERY good. Likewise with plate and mail armor proficiency, but to a lesser extent.

DESIGNING MONSTERS

Monsters should not simply be differently shaped bags of Hit Points. Each different kind monster (even with identical stats) should FEEL different to fight (their tactics, how they deal damage, how they avoid it, etc.). Monster groups (e.g., Kobolds, Goblins, Bandits) should have a share ability that all monsters of that type have. It should be simple but give a big sense of flavor for that monster. Goblins

laugh at you when you miss, kobolds get stabby when you kill their friends, bandits are crafty and particularly don't want to die! Each of these will make players engage with them differently and use different tactics.

In order for a heroic party to be able to have variety in their encounters with a monster group (and to be able to encounter them at varying levels), each

monster group should have a fairly wide band of monster levels, for example:

- **Kobolds:** LVL 1/3 to LVL 1
- **Goblins:** LVL 1/3 to LVL 2
- **Bandits:** LVL 1/3 to LVL 4
- **Snakemen:** LVL 1 to LVL 8

Don't feel the need to cover every level, especially if a monster's nature doesn't allow them to reasonably scale up or down to very high or low levels. Giants, for instance, their lowest level may be in the double digits, and that's okay.

MONSTER ROLES

Monster groups should also have creatures that can fulfil a variety of roles: Melee, Ranged, Controller, AoE, Summoner, Striker, Ambusher, etc. A GM need not even be aware of these, the design of each monster should make the optimal play pattern obvious. Some creatures can fill multiple roles for flexibility (e.g., goblins are equally good at range and in melee).

- **Melee:** Most effective when toe-to-toe.
- **Ranged.** Most effective at Range.
- **Controller.** Low damage, primarily hampers the heroes.
- **Support.** Primarily boosts the damage or abilities of their allies.
- **AoE.** Deals damage to multiple heroes at a time (cleaving strikes, shouts, auras, explosions, etc.)
- **Summoner.** Summons additional monsters to the battlefield (usually minions).
- **Striker.** High damage, low survivability.
- **Ambusher.** Not immediately visible when combat begins.
- **Defender.** High survivability, low damage.

DON'T LEAVE THE GM WONDERING WHAT TO DO

Give the GM a hand, make it as easy as possible to run the monster! Monster should always either

have 1 action to perform, or (if they have multiple abilities to choose from) 1 clear BEST action to perform. For instance a Troll can use either Claws or Bite. Bite deals far more damage, but it requires a creature to be Prone. Claws can knock prone. The order of operations is immediately clear, use Claw until someone falls down, then Bite.

Note also that the Troll's two attacks use the same die size to make running it easier and smoother for the GM, and one attack's damage is *clearly* much better than the other (Claw: 1d4+10, Bite 1d4+20). If Claw instead was 6d4 and Bite was 1d4+20, it'd be much less obvious which is stronger.

Monsters that will commonly fight together will ideally all use the same dice (e.g. goblins all use d6s, kobolds all use d4). This helps prevent the GM from needing to search for lots of different dice at the table. It's a very little thing, but every way we can make the GM's job easier, and remove mental overhead for them, means they have more capacity for strategy, role playing, lobbing insults, jokes, and telling an interesting story.

WHAT TO AVOID

Avoid monsters that heal. Subtracting and adding HP is fiddly. Monster can be given armor, more HP, or other defensive abilities instead, giving the same flavor but with reduced mechanics.

Avoid flying creatures (particularly at low levels). They are difficult to physically play at the table, and can be more frustrating than fun. Flying creatures can move around via flight, but should spend time on the ground to attack and in between turns. Think of them as highly mobile ground creatures that can more easily avoid opportunity attacks. At higher levels when heroes have more ways to deal with them you can include flight more often (but don't over do it). Adding a 3rd dimension to combat (flying) that is available to some, but not all is hard to pull off well in a TTRPG. Swimming and Climbing don't suffer from the same fate as this is available to all creatures (in the case of trees, cliffs, etc.), or even in the case of spiders and other monsters who can crawl upside down on ceilings, make sure there are plenty of ways to knock them down (on

damage, on crit, burn the webs, etc.).

Avoid complex individual monsters. Monster *groups* as a whole should *feel* tactically unique and complex without any of the parts actually *being* complex. Each monster should be very simple to run with a crystal clear “this is what I will do on my turn”

for the GM to execute. Consider how these different monsters will be mixed together (yes, an individual goblin or kobold isn’t particularly interesting to fight, but that will never happen— they only exist in a context of other kobolds and goblins.



SPELL FRAMEWORK

Spell Range. The typical spell Range is 8. This is because it is just beyond how far a creature can move in a single turn (6 spaces). Spells with less Range should have some benefit, spells with a longer Range should have some drawback.

Actions. Cantrips cost 1 action. Tiered spells typically cost 2 actions. If a spell is non-damaging it can be reduced to 1 action instead, if it is a Ranged AoE spell, it should cost 3 actions instead.

Spell Schools. Each spell school should have its own flavor and mechanics. Radiant spells, for instance, have Reach (not Range), aid allies and punish evildoers. Wind spells use the d4, are vicious, and interact a lot with movement. Ice spells are very defensive and controlling, etc.

Spell damage scaling. The average damage of a spell per tier is listed below. If a spell does more than the average it should have a drawback (limited range, status requirement, etc.), if it does less than this it should have some other utility or benefit (ignores armor, doesn’t miss, etc.).

Note. *These numbers assume no additional benefit or drawbacks, spells can and should deviate from the average once other benefits or drawbacks are considered.*

AVERAGE SPELL DAMAGE

- | | |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| • Cantrip. 6 damage. | • Tier 5. 56 damage. |
| • Tier 1. 14 damage. | • Tier 6. 69 damage. |
| • Tier 2. 23 damage. | • Tier 7. 83 damage. |
| • Tier 3. 33 damage. | • Tier 8. 98 damage. |
| • Tier 4. 44 damage. | • Tier 9. 114 damage. |

Remember! Damage is often NOT the most important aspect of a spell or ability. No single spell should be so good that it is the “go-to” spell in every situation. A spell’s secondary effects are frequently the most important, fun, and memorable aspects as they allow for more creativity. Having a toolbox of different spells that are each best in their own situation is far more interesting than hyper-consistent (boring) spells that always hit exactly on the average damage curve, have no restrictions, or other benefits, drawbacks, or weirdnesses.

Add wrinkles. Spells that *only* deal damage in a straightforward way are boring.

Avoid legalese. Spells, more than other abilities can fall prey to Legalese: the language lawyers speak in when writing contracts. Legalese is long-winded and not fun to read. Take for instance this iconic 5e spell:

Wish Level 9 conjuration, 1 Action, Range: Self, Components: V, Duration: Instantaneous

Wish is the mightiest spell a mortal can cast. By simply speaking aloud, you can alter reality itself. The basic use of this spell is to duplicate any other spell of level 8 or lower. If you use it this way, you don't need to meet any requirements to cast that spell, including costly components. The spell simply takes effect.

Alternatively, you can create one of the following effects of your choice: Object Creation. You create one object of up to 25,000 GP in value that isn't a magic item. The object can be no more than 300 feet in any dimension, and it appears in an unoccupied space that you can see on the ground.

Instant Health. You allow yourself and up to twenty creatures that you can see to regain all Hit Points, and you end all effects on them listed in the Greater Restoration spell. Resistance. You grant up to ten creatures that you can see Resistance to one damage type that you choose. This Resistance is permanent.

Spell Immunity. You grant up to ten creatures you can see immunity to a single spell or other magical effect for 8 hours. Sudden Learning. You replace one of your feats with another feat for which you are eligible. You lose all the benefits of the old feat and gain the benefits of the new one. You can't replace a feat that is a prerequisite for any of your other feats or features.

Roll Redo. You undo a single recent event by forcing a reroll of any die roll made within the last round (including your last turn). Reality reshapes itself to accommodate the new result. For example, a Wish spell could undo an ally's failed saving throw or a foe's Critical Hit. You can force the reroll to be made with Advantage or Disadvantage, and you choose whether to use the reroll or the original roll.

Reshape Reality. You may wish for something not included in any of the other effects. To do so, state your wish to the DM as precisely as possible. The DM has great latitude in ruling what occurs in such an instance; the greater the wish, the greater the likelihood that something goes wrong. This spell might simply fail, the effect you desire might be achieved only in part, or you might suffer an unforeseen consequence as a result of how you worded the wish. For example, wishing that a villain were dead might propel you forward in time to a period when that villain is no longer alive, effectively removing you from the game. Similarly, wishing for a Legendary magic item or an Artifact might instantly transport you to the presence of the item's current owner.

If your wish is granted and its effects have consequences for a whole community, region, or world,

you are likely to attract powerful foes. If your wish would affect a god, the god's divine servants might instantly intervene to prevent it or to encourage you to craft the wish in a particular way. If your wish would undo the multiverse itself, threaten the City of Sigil, or affect the Lady of Pain in any way, you see an image of her in your mind for a moment; she shakes her head, and your wish fails.

The stress of casting Wish to produce any effect other than duplicating another spell weakens you. After enduring that stress, each time you cast a spell until you finish a Long Rest, you take 1d10 Necrotic damage per level of that spell. This damage can't be reduced or prevented in any way. In addition, your Strength score becomes 3 for 2d4 days. For each of those days that you spend resting and doing nothing more than light activity, your remaining recovery time decreases by 2 days.

Finally, there is a 33 percent chance that you are unable to cast Wish ever again if you suffer this stress.

Long-winded specificity can also quash creativity. Even worse than its length, however, is how this kind of legalese can set up an adversarial expectations between the heroes and the GM. The game shouldn't expect players to word things "as precisely as possible" nor should it expect the GM try and foil the hero's request. A similar spell in Nimble it might look something like this:

Manifest Reality Tier 9 (1/Safe Rest)

Reshape reality itself in a single, decisive way (e.g., you could gain forbidden knowledge, conjure wealth, undo death, rewind time, or grant an extraordinary boon to yourself or allies). However, such immense power can be volatile—if your wish strains the fabric of reality too much, it may unravel in unpredictable ways. After casting, make a DC 10 STR save or permanently lose the ability to cast this spell. This DC increases by 1 each time you cast Wish.

Since this is a collaborative game with a GM who can fairly adjudicate anything that is unclear (and not adversarial contract law), we don't need that much detail. The players and the GM all want the most fun possible. Some examples are provided to help seed some possible ways this spell could be used, but beyond that, we should leave the specifics to the GM and players.

ADVENTURE FRAMEWORK

Emphasize tight writing, no extra stuff. Full sentences are neither necessary nor recommended. Prioritize brevity so the text can quickly be scanned at a glance and repeated in the GM's own words rather than read like a script.

COMPONENTS OF A TIGHT ADVENTURE:

Adventure Length. Roughly 800–1200 words total.

Cool, Evocative Name. Should get the GM excited to run it, and the Heroes excited to play it.

What Really Happened/Adventure Background. This is for the GM to read beforehand. It should contain secrets the heroes can discover as they play. Think of adventures as a mystery that is solved as the heroes delve further into it. What is the mystery/problem? How is it solved as we play? (100 words).

3 Adventure Hooks. Different factions who ask, different rewards promised. This makes it easier to slot into widely varying campaigns (100 words).

3-5 treasures. Not all will be given/found. Not necessarily powerful magical items. Interesting things to be used creatively. Some simple, maybe 1 powerful one (100 words).

2-4 Traveling/Exploration Events. (100-300 words) Complications/interesting things that happen along the way the players can respond to: foreshadowing a monster, getting lost, overcoming an obstacle, learn some backstory, motivate the heroes (these bad guys are really BAD because...), etc. These “set the stage” for the adventuring environment, how is this place different from other places? For example:

- **In a desert.** How can we make the heroes feel/struggle with the heat? Can we do anything with mirages? Lack of water? Sandstorms? Anything else to make it FEEL like the desert?
- **In a forest.** Do they get lost in the dense undergrowth? Are they hunted by beasts? Are they caught in goblin traps? Are they tricked by

a faerie? Can they ask the forest animals for aid?

- **In the sewers.** How bad does it smell, what effect does that have? Anything else unique about these particular sewers? Do the rats talk? Does the water contain magical runoff?

Dungeon Locations. 6-10 “rooms” (Doesn't have to be a literal dungeon. It could be a grove, palace, ruins, ravine, cave, sewers, hideout, airship, etc) This is the meat of the adventure (600 words, 50-80 words per room). Each room has:

- **Description.** A few words of descriptive text (max 1 sentence). The idea is that the GM can quickly scan this description and use it as the prompt for the heroes to begin interacting with the area, asking questions, etc. What do they immediately see, hear, etc. Give enough information for the heroes to start playing with, but no more.
- **Additional Bullets.** 2-3 additional things to interact with, accomplish, learn, etc. These are bullet points, they contain the answers to questions players will ask, the challenge present, the bits of interest.

Rooms Might Contain:

- **A trap/obstacle/problem.** The point of these rooms is to allow space for CREATIVITY and secondarily to expend resources. Traps/obstacles should almost always be obvious. Failing to successfully navigate it can result in damage, Wounds, conditions, alert others, make an enemy, loss of treasure (ONLY as of yet unobtained treasure—be VERY cautious with taking away treasure the heroes have already earned). These rooms can be designed with no particular solution, let the heroes come up with a solution.
- **Information.** Foreshadowing/information about the theme or direction of the adventure. These rooms can raise questions or provide answers to already existing questions.

Avoid Info Dumps. Unloading of a large amount of exposition all at once, often automatically and without the request of the heroes. **MAKE SURE** the heroes initiate any information you give them, and spread the information throughout a dungeon.

- **A Combat Encounter.** Each encounter should be scaled per hero so the GM doesn't need to adjust any numbers. What are the baddies doing when the heroes come? (NOT simply standing around). Combat can be the obvious answer, but not necessarily the *only* answer.
- **NPCs.** To fight (see above), to rescue, negotiate with, buy from, ally with, bamboozle, from another region/quest, to kidnap & ransom, etc.
- **Dilemmas.** If you take this path, you can't take the other path. If you ally with this faction, you cannot ally with the other, etc.
- **WEIRD things.** Crystals that produce "anti-light", Mind controlling fungus, Walls made of hands, Paintings with eyes that follow, room with no sound, feel smells, reversed gravity...

Agency. Each dungeon should maximize player agency. Rather than being strictly

linear, there should be some opportunity to meaningfully choose "this way or that way." Multiple ways to solve traps and puzzles, optional rooms, multiple entrances, secret passages, etc.

Ending. The end of a dungeon should have a satisfying climax, typically this means it culminates in a boss battle of some sort (not always, but usually). Any cool loot the boss has, expect the heroes to want to take. Adventures could end with negotiation, a plot twist, a revelation that "this thing goes way deep than any of us thought", a cliffhanger.

Aftermath. What happens (good or bad) after they return to town?

Maps. Ideally an adventure will include a map or simple flowchart of rooms. Make it simple enough that the layout can be drawn on the spot on a dry erase mat. Many players have trouble visualizing things in their minds, help them out!

Extra Notes. Think of any notes you'd create as you were reading through the adventure to prep for running it (e.g., simple role-playing ideas, monster statblocks, special rules reminders). If it's helpful for you, consider adding that to the adventure or clarifying whatever needed it. Do as much of the prep for the GM as possible!



AVERAGE HERO STATS

HERO LEVEL	HERO HP	HERO ARMOR	EFFECTIVE HP	DAMAGE PER TURN
1	15	5	32	10
2	21	7	45	12
3	28	9	60	14
4	34	10	70	16
5	41	11	80	18
6	47	12	90	21
7	54	13	100	24
8	60	14	110	27
9	67	15	120	30
10	73	16	130	33
11	79	17	140	36
12	86	18	150	39
13	92	19	160	42
14	99	20	170	45
15	105	22	182	48
16	112	24	196	51
17	118	26	209	54
18	125	28	223	57
19	131	30	236	60
20	137	34	256	64

Armor. This takes into account equipment and other defensive abilities (e.g., Ice Shield).

Effective HP. The base combat math assumes Heroes, on average, spend 1 action defensively per turn. This number includes the hero's Armor $\times$ the average number of rounds in an encounter.

Damage/Turn. This assumes 2 actions per turn spent offensively. Some classes will output less damage (but they can aid combat in other useful ways), others could output more if the situation is ideal (AoE abilities, assistance & setup from allies). This need not be a target per se, but if your numbers are very far off you should have a good reason for it.

Average Combat Length. Typical encounter math assumes 3–4 rounds of combat (or, for Legendary encounters, 15 hero turns). If an encounter lasts much longer than that it may start to feel like a slog; much shorter, and players may not have time to see the payoff to their setup and be disappointing.

Again, these are not hard rules! Some of the most fun is when we deviate from the average, just make sure you're doing it on purpose and for a good reason.



LEGENDARY MONSTERS

Give A Script! No need to write *everything* a legendary monster might say, but giving the GM a few lines to taunt the heroes is good fun. What do they say when they crit a hero? When they drop a hero to 0 HP? When they are bloodied or hit their last stand? Do they negotiate, do they taunt the heroes about releasing an even greater evil with their death? Do they alone have information the heroes desperately want? Egg the heroes on, make it memorable and special to fight legendary creatures. Here's an example from The Vanishing Caravans adventure in the GMG:

- **Opening Attack.** "You should have taken my offer. Now, I'm afraid I'll have to make this hurt!"
- **On Crit.** "Oh, did that sting? Good! I want you to remember it."
- **Gaining the Upper Hand:** "I'm almost starting to feel bad for you—almost."
- **Bloodied:** "You think this is over? I'm just getting warmed up!"
- **Last Stand:** "Did you really think I'd fight fair? You have no idea who you're dealing with!"
- **On Death:** "You think this ends with me? You're in deeper than you know... You've just made enemies in very high places..."

LEGENDARY MONSTER ENCOUNTERS

Legendary Monsters should be easy to run at a glance. Avoid the temptation toward too many mechanics that Interrupt The Flow, or those that are too fiddly.

The math behind solo/legendary encounters assumes roughly **15 hero turns** to get to the Last Stand. So a party of 3 heroes is expected to each get roughly 5 turns, a party of 5 heroes are expected to get 3 turns each.

Flow of Battle. What makes for an interesting

battle is uncertainty. If the bad guy is clerly winning and the heroes have no hope, it's not as much fun. Likewise if the heroes are clearly always winning and the bad guy has no hope, the excitement dampens. The most fun is where there are moments where it looks like the battle can go either way. At some portions of the fight, the heroes should be winning (typically early on in the fight), only for the bad guy to make a sudden comeback (Bloodied & Last Stand).

The HP/Damage values on the legendary monster chart allow for the heroes to have an edge in the first half of the fight, then for the bad guy's Bloodied effect to shift the tide of battle temporarily. The last stand should be a VERY dangerous situation to be in for more than just a few turns. This is when heroes can go all out to clinch a win!

Change it Up! *If you want to vary this cadence, you certainly can! You could make the boss extra difficult in the beginning, only for a severe weakness to show up when bloodied—just in time for the heroes to rally!*

Legendary Monster HP and Armor. All other things being equal, it's recommended that a legendary monster have Medium armor. If it is unarmored, make sure you compensate for thier survivability in some other way (see Dravok, All-Seeing Tyrant in the GMG). If they have Heavy armor make sure you're careful to give some weaknesses that can be taken advantage of, or make it degrade as the fight goes on, or improve to Heavy. An entire fight against a Heavily armored enemy can become a slow. The HP of a legendary monster with Medium Armor uses a multiplier of 80% compared to unarmored, heavy armor uses a multiplier of 60%. So an unarmored monster with 100 HP is roughly equivalent to one with medium armor and 80 HP, and 60 HP with heavy.

Low Levels. *The legendary monster chart in the GMG automatically accounts for lower levels since heroes tend to have fewer ways to deal with armor then.*